legacy usurped by his one-time deputy, Eknath Shinde, with the BJP's blessings of course. The two Senas are now at daggers drawn with each other to prove they are the rightful claimants to the Sena mantle.

Move eastward to West Bengal, which has 42 seats, and the redoubtable Mamata Banerjee, leader of the ruling Trinamool Congress (TMC), finds herself warding off a determined challenge from Suvendu Adhikari, once her general, and now the BJP commander in the state. This, after the saffron party had accused him of having his hand in the till with Mamata on various alleged scams, allegations that died down post his defection to their side. Now, the three-time chief minister is wrestling for control with archrival BJP.

In neighbouring Bihar, Chief Minister Nitish Kumar's political acrobatics of the past two years have left strategists astounded. Nitish first dumped the BJP to join hands with arch foe Lalu Prasad Yadav of the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD), even making his son, Tejashwi, a deputy chief minister. Then, this January, after several months of acting as the fulcrum of the Opposition alliance, Nitish dumped the lot and got into bed with the BJP again. It has now fallen upon Tejashwi, his back to the wall, to lead a determined charge against the combined might of the BJP and the JD(U).

So, what are the political equations that make these states the key deciders for the outcome of Election 2024? With the Congress failing miserably in direct contests with the BJP, losing 175 of 190 such seats in 2019, it is up to the regional satraps to challenge the might of the BJP. While Tamil Nadu chief minister M.K. Stalin successfully staved off the saffron challenge in the South in 2019, it is the regional stalwarts in Maharashtra, West Bengal and Bihar this time who are giving some semblance of an opposition to the BJP. The other two big regional parties—Jagan Reddy's Yuvajana Sramika Rythu Congress Party (YSRCP) in Andhra Pradesh and Naveen Patnaik's Biju Janata Dal (BJD) in Odisha—were at one point believed to have had a tacit understanding with the BJP not to oppose it on major national issues. That changed in 2024, when the BJP allied with Chandrababu Naidu's TDP in Andhra and the alliance with the BJD did not materialise. For the ruling party, it is important to extinguish the threat from these regional parties not only in the current general election but also in the assembly polls that will follow in the next two years. Andhra and Odisha, in fact, are going to the polls simultaneously with the Lok Sabha.

Were one to go by the 2019 Lok Sabha election result, Maharashtra and Bihar should have been a walkover for the BJP. In Maharashtra, for instance, the party won 23 of the state's 48 seats on its own in 2019, and 41 along with its National Democratic Alliance (NDA) partner, the then undivided Shiv Sena. In Bihar, the BJP had contested 17 seats and won all; the NDA swept 39 of the 40 seats overall. In West Bengal, the BJP had delivered a rude shock to Mamata in 2019, increasing its individual tally

THE SWING STATES

Accounting for nearly a fourth of the Lok Sabha seats, these three states will play a key role in deciding the fate of numerous regional power centres and the Congress. The ever-changing political equations make these contests even more intriguing

MAHARASHTRA

(Total seats: 48)

In the past two general elections, the Shiv Sena was part of the NDA and the NCP was with the UPA; after vertical splits in both parties, a residual faction each has aligned with the BJP and the Congress

IN THE FRAY

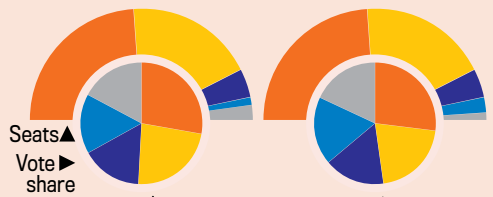


MAHAYUTI (NDA)
- BJP **28**
- Shiv Sena **15**
- NCP **4**
- RSP **1**

MAHA VIKAS AGHADI (INDIA)
- Shiv Sena (UBT) **21**
- Congress **17**
- NCP (SCP) **10**

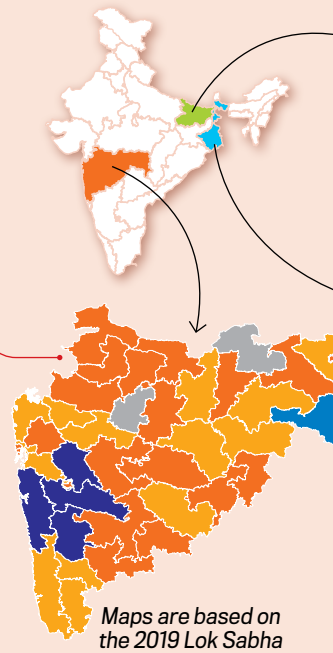
(Figures denote seats being contested)

PAST RESULTS



	2019	2014
BJP	**23**/25 (28%)	**23**/24 (27%)
Shiv Sena	**18**/23 (23%)	**18**/20 (21%)
NCP	**4**/19 (16%)	**4**/21 (16%)
Congress	**1**/25 (16%)	**2**/26 (18%)
Others	**2** (17%)	**1** (18%)

SEATS WON/ CONTESTED (VOTE SHARE)



Maps are based on the 2019 Lok Sabha election results